Theory and Methodology of Science (TaMoS)
Ethics of Medical Technology
Division of Philosophy | KTH Royal Institute of Technology
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Handout for Project Part - Seminar 1: Methods of applied ethics

Case

Brown's Deep Brain Stimulation

Brown is suffering from Parkinson's disease and has been offered Deep Brain Stimulation (DBS) treatment. In DBS treatment, a device sends electrical impulses through electrodes implanted into the patient's brain to stimulate specific parts of it. The treatment is very likely to be effective in Brown's case, although some side-effects should be expected.

Among other things, it is possible that the treatment will cause Brown to develop new character traits. After the surgery she may find that, for instance, she has a new taste in art, food, or entertainment. Such minor changes are very common. However, major changes are also possible. For instance, Brown may find her career dissatisfying, her social network terribly dull, she may stop loving her partner, or become religious/atheist (depending on her previous beliefs).

The probabilities for such major changes are quite small but still real. On the positive side, DBS treatment is usually reversible; the electrodes can be removed with little risk. However, it is possible that Brown-after-the surgery quite likes her new self and thus does not want to reverse and go back to her old self.

Thus, there are a set of moral questions involved with the case.

Is it wrong to offer Brown DBS treatment (given the risks)? Should Brown, before treatment, sign a contract which states that this or that personality change is unacceptable and that, if they occur, the procedure should be reversed. Should it be Brown's husband who makes such healthcare decisions for his wife (if he was to think that his wife is no longer herself)? Should it be the doctor's decision or would that be medical paternalism? Who should be allowed to make healthcare decisions for Brown?

In conclusion, there are various moral problems connected to DBS as a medical technology. The treatment should be supplemented with normative rules or principles providing guidance with regard to its use in healthcare.

Instructions

Your task is to provide normative guidance regarding the use of DBS treatment in healthcare. Formulate your answers with clarity, i.e., avoid ambiguity and vagueness. Begin by carefully reading the instructions.

At the end of the seminar, students from each group will be arbitrarily chosen to present the group's views before the whole class. Therefore, everyone should participate actively in the group discussions and take note of the progress.

1.) Solve the moral problem by taking a *bottom-up approach* to it, taking realistic expectations into account.

a.) Identify relevant stakeholders involved. How strong are their claims in this case?

i.) Brown?

ii.) Brown's husband?

iii.) The healthcare personnel (i.e. her doctor etc.)?

iv.) The general public?

v.) Others?

b.) Identify the values involved.

i.) Which are the main value conflicts?

ii.) Are the values equally reasonable or are some stronger than others?

2.) Solve the moral problem by using principlism.

a.) Name and describe its four principles

b.) Specify which principles you apply in Brown's Deep Brain Stimulation?

c.) Describe the main conflict between the principles.

d.) Try to reach a balanced judgement.
Motivate how you reached this judgement.

3.) Formulate a thesis regarding the case

a.) What is your thesis?

b.) What is the strongest argument supporting your thesis?

c.) What is the strongest argument against your thesis?